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Management Decision

Multidimensional customer experience in the sustainability context

Umut Unal
Department of Management, Istanbul Medeniyet University, Istanbul, Turkey
Rıfgı Buğra Bağcı
Department of Business Administration, Istanbul Sabahattin Zaim University, Istanbul, Turkey and
Department of Operations Management, Copenhagen Business School, Frederiksberg, Denmark, and
Mertcan Taşçıoğlu
Department of Management, Istanbul Medeniyet University, Istanbul, Turkey

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to examine the interaction among sustainability perceptions, customer experience and consumers' behavioral outcomes, showing companies an intersection where it is possible to maintain both corporate sustainability and achieve successful customer experience management.

Design/methodology/approach – A structural equation model was employed, using survey data collected from 375 participants to test the model and corresponding hypotheses. A stimulus-organism-response (SOR) model was incorporated as the theoretical framework.

Findings – In this study, a stimulus is conceptualized as internal, i.e. sustainability self-identity and sustainability consciousness and external, i.e. corporate sustainability image and reputation. Customer experience is modeled as a multifaced factor, consisting of emotional, cognitive, sensory, behavioral and social dimensions. The findings show that sustainability-related internal and external stimuli improve overall customer experience, which in turn leads to higher purchase intention, satisfaction and loyalty.

Originality/value – This paper contributes to the management, sustainability and customer experience literature by addressing the calls to link these two previously separate domains. Secondly, it identifies and classifies the sustainability-related stimuli that improve customer experiences, enriching this domain's theoretical and practical framework. Moreover, it presents crucial managerial implications by revealing the impact of integrating sustainability principles into corporate strategies on improving customer experiences and creating favorable behavioral outcomes.

Keywords Sustainability, Customer experience, Stimulus-organism-response model, Structural equation

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

In recent years, customer experience (CX) has gained widespread attention in business research, with many managers and researchers now focusing on this topic. Although it is not a new concept, in the last decade CX has enjoyed a renewed interest thanks to the growing appreciation of the role of experience marketing in the customer-firm relationship management (Ünal *et al.*, 2024; Wetzels *et al.*, 2023). Executives rank customer experience as a top priority (HBR, 2021), and academics view it as an effective strategy for persistent competitive advantage (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Pekovic and Rolland, 2020). Likewise, in recent years, the issue of sustainability has become very popular among businesses and is considered one of the most important factors for gaining a competitive advantage (Elmassri *et al.*, 2023; Fatima and Elbanna, 2023; Qu and Mardani, 2023). Hence, organizations are leaning towards creating sustainability-led and customer experience-centered marketing campaigns. However, there is a dearth of research on the linkages between these dimensions and how they will drive consumer behavior in the current competitive climate (Ünal *et al.*, 2024). Given the current

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business landscape and growing emphasis on sustainability, customer experience, and the strategic importance of competitive advantage in a broader spectrum, we argue that it is an opportune time to study these two ideas together.

Although CX and sustainability have received increased research attention over the recent years (Arkadan *et al.*, 2024; Le *et al.*, 2024; Velasco *et al.*, 2024), they were largely considered separate fields of investigation. Although past studies have investigated the factors that influence customer experience (Pusceddu *et al.*, 2023; Yingfei *et al.*, 2022), there remains a significant gap in understanding how sustainability relates to customer experience. As the literature has traditionally considered sustainability and customer experience as separate variables rather than interrelated, there is a lack of understanding of how these concepts are related (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Ünal *et al.*, 2024). However, one recent stream of research that has garnered increasing scholarly attention evaluates how responsive consumers are to sustainability efforts in general (Jung *et al.*, 2020; Tsetse *et al.*, 2024). This has forced businesses to be aware that the very principles of sustainability and customer experience are the backbone of a company (Jiang *et al.*, 2023). Consequently, companies are required to adopt a strategic approach to pursue both of them effectively in their management strategies (Becker and Jaakkola, 2020; Elmassri *et al.*, 2023). As customers become aware of and attracted to sustainable processes, many researchers have noted their tendency to view organizations without sustainable strategies as unfavorable (Unal and Tascioglu, 2022; Waqas *et al.*, 2023). However, companies' practical implementation of such a strategy remains a challenge, prompting ongoing investigations in management research (Calza *et al.*, 2023).

The rationale for this study is based on the proposition that in the sustainability context, the potential for enhancing customer experience and, therefore, consumers' satisfaction, loyalty, and purchase intention is best captured by the companies' sustainability reputation and image, as well as consumers' self-identity and sustainability consciousness. While several studies analyze the impact of sustainability initiatives on consumer behavior (e.g. Agnihotri *et al.*, 2022; Gelderman *et al.*, 2021), the impact of sustainability stimuli on customer experience has remained surprisingly understudied. Thus, it is essential to examine the role of customer experience in the relationship linking sustainability and consumer behavior.

This research employs the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model to analyze the internal and external stimuli that influence consumers. There are two primary reasons why the SOR framework is particularly applicable to this study. First, the stimuli-behavioral relationship has been extensively utilized by management scholars in examining behavioral responses associated with sustainability, such as understanding consumer attitudes towards sustainable luxury brands (Aggarwal *et al.*, 2024), uncovering the motivations driving consumers for green customization (Wang *et al.*, 2024). It is also used to explain employee behaviors such as emotional engagement (Mednini and Damak Turki, 2024) and voice behavior (De Clercq and Pereira, 2023). Second, the SOR framework provides a logical and structured method of understanding how internal and external stimuli affect customers' experiences and how they respond to them. The SOR framework enables the analysis of the relationship between the stimuli and how they influence consumers, which is useful in understanding the consumers' behavior.

While prior research has thoroughly investigated general stimuli such as corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives and organizational change (Servaes *et al.*, 2023; Wang *et al.*, 2024), this study expands the scope by introducing novel sustainability-oriented stimuli, including corporate sustainability reputation, sustainability self-identity, and sustainability consciousness. These constructs offer a fresh perspective by capturing the complex relationship between individual and societal expectations, shedding light on the psychological and emotional mechanisms driving sustainable consumer behavior within the SOR framework. By positioning sustainability as a dynamic and multifaceted stimulus, the study not only highlights its role in triggering individual cognitive and emotional responses but

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also underscores its capacity to reshape broader perceptions of customer experience, ultimately enriching the understanding of sustainability's influence in contemporary consumer contexts.

Accordingly, this study makes significant contributions to management, sustainability, and customer experience literature by answering several research calls. Its first and foremost contribution is the exploration of the role of multidimensional customer experience in customer-firm relationship management through a comprehensive probe into behavioral outcomes such as satisfaction and loyalty (Calza *et al.*, 2023). Secondly, it examines the impact of several sustainability triggers, i.e. sustainability self-identity, sustainability consciousness, corporate sustainability reputation, and image, on customer experience (Ünal *et al.*, 2024) as an attempt to identify stimuli shaping sustainable customer experience (SCE) which is "derived by sensations, feelings, cognitions, and behaviors evoked by sustainable stimuli, based on economic, social and environmental sustainability" (Signori *et al.*, 2019, p. 161). Even though the literature presumes a positive link between these stimuli and customer experience (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Kotler *et al.*, 2021; Kumar and Venkatesan, 2021), this assumption has not passed well beyond the conceptual level. Except for a handful of studies (e.g. Hengboriboon *et al.*, 2022; Roseta *et al.*, 2020), the direct relationships between the aforementioned stimuli and customer experience have not been examined empirically, making it imperative to test those relationships in an experimental way. Therefore, our study fills a significant gap in the literature. Thus, by building the sequential relationships linking sustainability stimuli, CX and customer behavior, it answers the calls to investigate the role of CX in connecting sustainability perceptions and customer responses (Khan and Fatma, 2023). Third, by exploring the effects of both internal stimuli related to consumers' sustainability perceptions and external stimuli focusing on companies' sustainability practices, it advances the theoretical understanding of the stimuli-organism-response framework. The traditional SOR framework considers stimuli as external factors affecting individuals' inner states (Bagozzi, 1986). It was afterward reconceptualized to include both external and internal stimuli (Jacoby, 2002). However, it is much more usual than not that studies opt to focus on either external or internal stimuli in isolation (Chahal *et al.*, 2024). Our study incorporates both external and internal stimuli into the research model in combination, which offers a broader understanding and captures various dimensions simultaneously. In doing so, together with a limited number of studies in the literature using such a dichotomous structure (e.g. Goyal *et al.*, 2022; Piligrimiene *et al.*, 2020), we set an example for the simultaneous employment of external and internal stimuli in SOR framework. We begin by explaining SOR theory and literature to build our conceptual model. We then discuss the findings of the study along with implications and limitations.

Theoretical background

Sustainability and Stimulus Organism Response (SOR) model

The Anthropocene has brought profound ecological, economic, and social changes that reshape consumer behaviors toward sustainability (Zameer *et al.*, 2024). Sustainability, defined as meeting present needs without compromising future resources (Sikdar, 2020), has been explored using theories such as planned behavior (Wang *et al.*, 2023), behavioral reasoning (Ünal *et al.*, 2024), and personality traits (Salem and Alanadoly, 2021). However, these approaches often fail to capture the nuanced interaction between cognitive, emotional, and behavioral processes (Calza *et al.*, 2023). The Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) framework (Jacoby, 2002) offers a more comprehensive lens for understanding these dynamics. Its three components—stimulus (internal and external triggers), organism (inner cognitive and emotional processes), and response (behavioral outcomes)—are widely applied in examining consumer (Wang *et al.*, 2024) and employee behaviors (Hesselbarth *et al.*, 2023).

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Recently, the stimuli-behavioral outcome relationship has been used by management scholars to study brand-related stimuli driving emotional engagement (Mednini and Damak Turki, 2024) and organizational changes influencing employee responses (De Clercq and Pereira, 2023; Teodorovicz *et al.*, 2024). It has also been proven valuable in assessing sustainability practices as sustainability-related stimuli are found to shape internal states and behaviors of both customers and employees. For instance, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives aligned with employees' values encourage positive workplace behaviors (Liao *et al.*, 2024). Similarly, companies' sustainability practices enhance customer satisfaction by building a positive link with their emotional and societal values (Shih *et al.*, 2024). Additionally, organizations are increasingly compelled by societal demands to adopt sustainable practices, a shift driven by evolving accountability dynamics (Bamiatzi *et al.*, 2024; Ferguson, 2024). Despite its utility, a gap remains in understanding how sustainability-oriented stimuli such as corporate reputation, self-identity, and consciousness—shape customer experiences. The current study addresses this research gap by applying the SOR framework to explore how sustainability influences purchase intentions, satisfaction, and loyalty. By contextualizing sustainability as a critical stimulus, this work contributes to management literature and informs strategies for integrating sustainable practices with customer engagement.

Hypothesis development

Stimulus and organism

Customer experience. The term "customer experience" refers to the overall impact of consumers based on their interactions with products, services, and touchpoints such as advertising and customer service (Lemon and Verhoef, 2016). Sustainability emphasizes the role of customer experience in designing the desired outcomes. These steps encompass a variety of factors and perspectives, which scholars have explored in the context of management research (Sheth *et al.*, 2023; Stead *et al.*, 2022). Customer experience, as demonstrated by Verhoef *et al.* (2009), spans emotional, cognitive, sensory, behavioral, and social aspects across the customer journey.

In consumption, "emotions" refer to emotional reactions triggered by consumer experiences (Manthiou *et al.*, 2020). Emotions play a pivotal role in the perception of customer experience (Kim and Perdue, 2013), and their interaction with consumer equity drivers can be positive or negative (Verhoef *et al.*, 2009). Consumption-related feelings influence customer behaviors (Dubé and Menon, 2000), e.g. impacting loyalty directly (Diallo *et al.*, 2018) and indirectly (Godefroit-Winkel *et al.*, 2022). Cognitive processes that stimulate creativity or problem-solving can challenge customers' preconceptions about goods or services (Schmitt and Delft, 2011). While cognitive experiences are examined, there is limited study on how customers perceive cognitive experiences (Pekovic and Rolland, 2020). Logic and cognition influence customers, particularly when they purchase with intent or high expectations. Task-oriented customers prioritize factors like price and quality in their experiences.

Sensory experience relates to consumer environments, including ambiance, products, and services, evoking reactions (Schmitt and Delft, 2011) that stem from human senses – smell, sound, sight, taste, and touch (Lusch and Vargo, 2021). Behavioral outcomes toward offerings are shaped by sensory experience and evaluation (Fakfare *et al.*, 2021). For instance, ambient cues impact consumer outcomes like store time (Ballantine *et al.*, 2015). Social experience involves interactions between individuals like coworkers and customers (Hamilton *et al.*, 2021). Customer loyalty can develop from customer-employee interactions even more than artificial intelligence (Prentice and Nguyen, 2020). Our study employed customer experience as a combination of these five dimensions, as suggested by Verhoef *et al.* (2009).

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Sustainability self-identity. Self-identity, distinguishing one's character within a specific activity (Oyserman *et al.*, 2012), goes beyond needs, extending to self-presentation through consumption (Bagozzi *et al.*, 2013) and influences consumer judgment in purchasing (Malik *et al.*, 2020). Being linked to green concerns and reflecting one's eco-responsible behavior (van der Werff *et al.*, 2014), sustainability self-identity identifies as pro-sustainable, driving actions favoring sustainable products (Clayton and Saunders, 2012).

Prior research consistently reveals self-identity's substantial impact on consumer decisions (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2022), outweighing attitudes or values (Gatersleben *et al.*, 2014). Similarly, it has been shown that customers who identify with a brand's sustainability initiatives are more likely to have positive experiences with the brand (Mishra *et al.*, 2022). Our study leverages sustainability self-identity as a stimulus within the sustainability-customer experience relationship and posits that customers' sustainability self-identity leads them to form more favorable experience perceptions towards sustainable products and services.

Therefore, we expect to see a positive relationship between consumers' sustainability self-identity and their experiences.

Sustainability consciousness. Experience itself may be considered a definition of consciousness, and anything we can see or feel can serve as an example of consciousness (Velmans, 2009). The experience or understanding of sustainability phenomena is thus referred to as sustainability consciousness, which includes the sensations, experiences, and perceptions we frequently associate with ourselves, such as our beliefs, emotions, and behaviors (Gericke *et al.*, 2019).

Evoking positive experiences and behavioral outcomes through sustainability consciousness encompasses various facets, mirroring the multifaceted nature of this construct (Saari *et al.*, 2020). Scholars have revealed its positive influence on consumer actions, such as choosing eco-friendly products, supporting environmentally responsible brands, and recommending sustainable practices (Kautish *et al.*, 2019). Sustainable individuals engage in pro-environmental behaviors beyond their immediate consumption choices, including recycling, conserving energy, and participating in environmental initiatives (Zameer *et al.*, 2024). Following these findings, we expect to find a positive linkage between customers' sustainability consciousness and how they rate their experiences with sustainable products and services.

Our study takes these two stimuli, i.e. sustainability self-identity and sustainability consciousness, as internal stimuli that shape consumers' experiences. Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H1. Internal sustainability stimuli, composed of sustainability self-identity and consciousness, are positively related to customer experience.

Corporate sustainability reputation. Corporate reputation reflects public perception of a company's standing (Fombrun, 1996). Corporate sustainability reputation distinguishes companies from their competitors based on their sustainability traits (Dowling, 2004). Developing distinctiveness entails trustworthy acts and fostering confidence (Elmassri *et al.*, 2023). Earlier research ties corporate reputation to customer outcomes like satisfaction (Özkan *et al.*, 2020), loyalty (O'Connor and Assaker, 2022), enhanced trust, and lower perceived risk (Unal and Tascioglu, 2022). We contend that because many service providers are similar, clients use reputation as a distinction. Therefore, customer experience should be positively correlated with corporate sustainability reputation because customers may perceive greater quality and/or value of a product/service when their provider has a strong reputation (Elmassri *et al.*, 2023).

The relationship between corporate reputation and customer experience within the context of sustainability is an emerging area of research, with scholars increasingly recognizing its significance (Amos *et al.*, 2019). This dynamic interplay between reputation and experience can reshape our understanding of how sustainability initiatives influence consumer perceptions and behaviors, recognizing the potential of sustainability practices to achieve

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societal good and create greater customer experience at the same time (Kumar and Venkatesan, 2021). Therefore, we expect to see a positive impact of a favorable corporate sustainability reputation on consumers' experiences on a multidimensional level.

Corporate sustainability image. Corporate sustainability image, an integral facet of corporate image, holds a significant position in marketing and corporate strategy. As Dowling (2004) posits, it encapsulates the essence of "What do people think about you?"—a reflection of stakeholder perceptions shaped by communications (Gelderman *et al.*, 2021; Le *et al.*, 2022). Corporate image captures tangible and intangible facets that resonate among public opinion (Jung *et al.*, 2020; Zameer *et al.*, 2024).

This dimension, corporate sustainability image, receives increasing attention. It reflects customer perceptions regarding a company's commitment to sustainability, encompassing environmental and social concerns (Gelderman *et al.*, 2021). Beyond traditional business metrics, it signifies dedication to ecological responsibility and social welfare (Macchion *et al.*, 2018). Engaging in socially responsible activities bolsters a favorable corporate image, resonating positively with stakeholders and leading to better customer experience (Yingfei *et al.*, 2022).

Given the importance of the link between corporate image and enduring trust, firms can enhance legitimacy and trust by improving perceptions of sustainability (Leong *et al.*, 2022; Panda *et al.*, 2020). This underscores the strategic importance of aligning corporate image with sustainability credibility. Despite the growing importance of corporate image and sustainability concerns (Le *et al.*, 2022), corporate sustainability image remains understudied (Grewal and Serafeim, 2020; Zameer *et al.*, 2024). This research aims to address this gap, utilizing sustainability image as a predictor of customer experience.

Our study employs these two stimuli, i.e. corporate sustainability reputation and corporate sustainability image, as external stimuli that shape consumers' experiences. Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H2. External sustainability stimuli, composed of corporate sustainability reputation and corporate sustainability image, are positively related to customer experience.

Response

The present study uses purchase intention, satisfaction, and loyalty as response behaviors. Customer experience describes the perceived value of a product or service, which affects consumer behavior (Bağcı and Taşçıoğlu, 2024; Stead *et al.*, 2022; Yingfei *et al.*, 2022). Several empirical studies have supported the positive relationship between customer experience and behavior. Notably, previous research (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Ünal *et al.*, 2024; Wibowo *et al.*, 2021) highlighted the importance of experience in influencing a customer's sustainable behavior. Accordingly, customer experience has been found to affect repurchase intention (Yingfei *et al.*, 2022), satisfaction (Cepeda-Carrión *et al.*, 2023), and loyalty (Stein and Ramaseshan, 2020).

H3. Customer experience is positively related to purchase intention

H4. Customer experience is positively related to satisfaction

H5. Customer experience is positively related to loyalty

Figure 1 represents the theoretical model of the present study.

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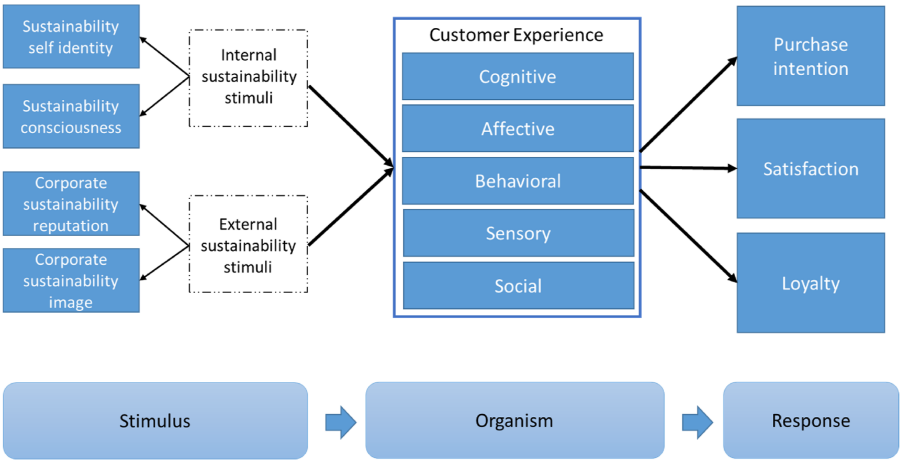


Figure 1. Theoretical model. Source: Authors' own work

Research method

Sampling and measures

This study was conducted through data collected using an online five-point Likert scale questionnaire. Data collection for this study was conducted through an online survey distributed by students acting as data collectors, incentivized with extra credit (Boyle and Schmierbach, 2003). These students shared the survey with non-student adults, such as family members, to ensure a diverse respondent pool and mitigate the limitations of a student-only sample. This approach, widely used in consumer studies, enabled efficient access to a broader audience while enhancing the generalizability of findings (Bağcı and Taşçıoğlu, 2024; Moon and Armstrong, 2020). Initially, the data consisted of 398 surveys; nevertheless, due to inadequate responses, 23 were removed from the sample, leaving 375 valid responses in the final sample. This sample size is considered adequate for the research model in this study, as per the guideline that the observations to estimated parameters ratio (N:q) should range from 5 to 10 (Bentler and Chou, 1987).

The sample shows an even distribution in terms of gender, 49% of whom are female while 51% are male. The majority of the respondents are between the ages of 31–40 (54%). Most of the respondents (45%) have bachelor's degrees, followed by 18% who have graduate degrees. Similarly, the majority of the participants have a monthly earning on or above the middle-income level. Therefore, the sample, resulting in a demographic profile with high education and income levels, is suitable for the purposes of this current study following the findings by Horani (2020) that the target customer groups for sustainable products and services are primarily individuals with higher education and income levels.

At the beginning of the survey, a basic and simplified definition of sustainability was provided along with characteristic examples for each sustainability dimension to ascertain participants had an accurate understanding of the concept before responding to the questions. Next, keeping the sustainability definition provided at the outset in mind, the participants were requested to consider a "sustainable" company from which they had purchased a product or service recently. To facilitate this, they were given a list of companies, which included the top-rated companies in the Istanbul Stock Exchange Sustainability Index. The Stock Exchange Sustainability Index was established in 2014 and aims to evaluate companies' sustainability performances based on global ESG (environmental, social, and financial governance) criteria. The participants were requested to either select one firm from the list or choose "other" at the bottom of the list and write in the name of another company that would best fit the

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sustainability image in their comprehension. Then, they were asked to answer the survey questions thinking of the sustainable company they picked and their past experiences with the product or service of that company. This method was intended to help participants relate their responses to a specific, real-life occurrence. In a recent paper, Ünal *et al*. (2024) used this procedure to examine the impact of customer experience in the context of sustainability. The present paper followed the same strategy when designing the methodology for this study.

Accordingly, well-established scales were taken from the literature to measure the constructs in the research model. Internal sustainability stimuli variable was modeled as a second-order reflective construct, consisting of sustainability self-identity, which was measured by items taken from Chen (2020), and sustainability consciousness, measured using items developed by Gericke *et al*. (2019). Similarly, external sustainability stimuli scale was formulated with items that are used to measure corporate sustainability reputation, adapted from Walsh and Beatty (2007) and corporate sustainability image, adapted from Amores-Salvadó *et al.* (2014) and Chen (2007). The EFA of both constructs is shown in Table 1 and 2. For purchase intention, items from Kumar *et al.* (2017), for satisfaction, from Moise *et al.* (2019) and Gelderman *et al.* (2021), and for loyalty, from Gelderman *et al*. (2021) and Wibowo *et al.* (2021) were employed. Finally, customer experience was measured as a construct comprising five sub-dimensions: cognitive, affective, behavioral, sensorial, and social. This scale was taken from Ünal *et al.* (2024), who adapted the measurement items from Ebrahim *et al*. (2016), Pekovic and Rolland (2020), Rather (2020) and Wibowo *et al*. (2021) to sustainability setting.

Data analysis

The present study employed structural equation modeling (SEM), which is in line with recent research standards (Hair *et al.*, 2021). As a second-generation analytical approach, SEM represents a combination of regression and factor analysis and is presented as ideal and more

Table 1. EFA of internal sustainability stimuli

	Component	
	1	2
SSI1		0.778
SSI2		0.843
SSI3		0.825
SSI4		0.858
SSI5		0.873
SSI6		0.820
SSI7		0.829
SSI8		0.786
SCEN1	0.792	
SCEN2	0.827	
SCEN3	0.834	
SCEN4	0.808	
SCSOC1	0.792	
SCSOC2	0.851	
SCSOC3	0.767	
SCECO1	0.869	
SCECO2	0.827	
SCECO3	0.815	
SCECO4	0.788	

Note(s): Extraction method: Principal Component Analysis
Rotation method: Promax with Kaiser Normalization
Source(s): Authors' own work

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Table 2. EFA of external sustainability stimuli

	Component 1	2
SUSREP1	0.732	
SUSREP2	0.803	
SUSREP3	0.788	
SUSREP4	0.762	
SUSREP5	0.765	
SUSREP6	0.765	
SUSIMG1		0.728
SUSIMG2		0.704
SUSIMG3		0.774
SUSIMG4		0.819
SUSIMG5		0.836

Note(s): Extraction method: Principal Component Analysis
Rotation method: Promax with Kaiser Normalization
Source(s): Authors' own work

dynamic compared to first-generation approaches such as multiple regression analysis (Bagozzi and Yi, 2012). The increasing use of complex, intricate, and elaborate research models has made SEM more acceptable for data analysis in business and management research in recent decades (Martínez-López *et al.*, 2013; Ünal, 2021). Adopting SEM allowed us to navigate past the limitations related to first-generation methods, such as working under the assumption of no measurement error (Hair *et al.*, 2021). The study's data analysis was conducted using IBM's SPSS (25th version) for initial data preparation and AMOS software (24th version) for the SEM analyses. As the first step, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted to test the fit between the collected data and our theoretically proposed model. The indices showed that the proposed model and the data fit well (CFI = 0.92, IFI = 0.92, TLI = 0.92, RMSEA = 0.046, $p < 0.001$).

Following this, we tested scale reliability, which refers to the measure of internal consistency—that is, the extent to which the items in a scale are related as a group. Composite reliability (CR) values of each construct were noticeably higher than the recommended threshold of 0.7 (Hair *et al.*, 2021), affirming that the scales are reliable. Secondly, we analyzed the validity of the constructs by examining two subtypes: convergent validity and discriminant validity. Convergent validity checks whether all the items under the same construct, which are theoretically related to each other, are indeed interrelated. Discriminant validity, on the other hand, monitors the opposite, that is, whether theoretically distinct constructs are really diverging from each other as they are supposed to be. To begin with the convergence, we calculated the AVE values of each construct, each above the cut-off point of 0.5 (Fornell and Larcker, 1981), confirming adequate convergent validity. As for the discriminant validity measurement, HTMT analysis was conducted. All the values were below the threshold of 0.90 proposed by (Hair *et al.*, 2021), verifying that discriminant validity is established as well. Therefore, it was concluded that none of the constructs had any concern about either reliability or validity (see Table 3).

Next, before proceeding to the structural model to test the proposed hypotheses, we checked for common method bias (CMB), which is the artificially depleted or inflated variance that occurred not due to the relationships proposed in the research model but by external factors such as social desirability (Jordan and Troth, 2019). Rodríguez-Ardura and Meseguer-Artola (2020) highlight that CMB can cast serious doubt on the validity of research findings and propose several methods as preventive measures against CMB. Following their suggestions, as described in the research methodology section, we provided a basic

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Table 3. Reliability and validity analysis

Construct	CR	CA	AVE	HTMT I	II	III	IV	V	VI	VII	VIII
(I) Sustainability consciousness	0.95	0.95	0.63								
(II) Corporate sustainability image	0.84	0.84	0.51	0.30							
(III) Sustainability self-identity	0.94	0.93	0.64	0.74	0.29						
(IV) Sustainability reputation	0.87	0.87	0.52	0.32	0.85	0.34					
(V) Customer experience	0.94	0.95	0.56	0.44	0.69	0.42	0.63				
(VI) Purchase intention	0.90	0.90	0.75	0.45	0.54	0.45	0.55	0.66			
(VII) Satisfaction	0.91	0.90	0.62	0.61	0.52	0.56	0.54	0.73	0.75		
(VIII) Loyalty	0.91	0.91	0.71	0.54	0.44	0.50	0.41	0.64	0.72	0.82	

Source(s): Authors' own work

definition of sustainability along with typical examples for each dimension in order to avoid any potential misunderstanding or misinterpretation of the scale items. Moreover, at the outset of the survey, we explicitly guaranteed the participant's anonymity to ensure the authenticity of their responses. Later, we applied Harman's single-factor test and found that single factor accounted for only 34.2% of the total variance explained, which is significantly lower than the 50% threshold (MacKenzie and Podsakoff, 2012). Consequently, we concluded that CMB is not a problem in the present study.

Moreover, we conducted common latent factor analysis (MacKenzie and Podsakoff, 2012). Accordingly, we compared the factor loadings and fit indices from the model incorporating the common latent factor with those from the standard measurement model, and no significant differences were observed. Finally, to evaluate the presence of non-response bias in our dataset, we conducted a comparative analysis between early and late respondents. The first quartile of responses was classified as early respondents, while the final quartile represented late respondents. Using chi-square tests, we examined potential disparities between these groups. The results indicated no statistically significant differences, suggesting that non-response bias is unlikely to have skewed our findings. This reinforces the robustness and representativeness of our sample.

Structural model results

Following the appropriate results in analyzing the measurement model, we proceed to test the hypothesized relationships in the structural model. The standardized coefficients of the paths estimated in the model are shown in Table 4. The results show that both internal and external sustainability stimuli significantly enhance customer experience. Again, all the paths are

Table 4. Structural equation model results

	Path	β	*t*	Support
H1	Internal Sustainability Stimuli → Customer Experience	0.36***	5.83	Yes
H2	External Sustainability Stimuli → Customer Experience	0.50***	9.53	Yes
H3	Customer Experience → Purchase Intention	0.89***	11.71	Yes
H4	Customer Experience → Satisfaction	0.86***	11.95	Yes
H5	Customer Experience → Loyalty	0.79***	11.07	Yes

Note(s): CFI = 0.93 IFI = 0.93 TLI = 0.93 RMSEA = 0.04
*$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Authors' own work

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statistically significant when it comes to the effect of customer experience on purchase intention, satisfaction, and loyalty. Therefore, all the hypotheses are supported.

Further, to ensure the rigorousness of this study, two alternative models were created and compared with the proposed model. In the first alternative model, we broke down the second-order constructs into first-order variables (Figure 2). This alternative model produced a lower but still acceptable model fit. In this model, each sustainability stimulus has a positive impact on customer experience, which in turn, enhances purchase intention, satisfaction, and loyalty significantly (see Table 5). In addition, we added three control variables to the model (age, gender, and sector). The results show that the age and gender of the respondents do not exert any significant impact on the outcomes ($p > 0.05$ in all paths). As for the third control variable, we tested if the results differ depending on the sector of the company from which the respondents bought a product or service. Based on the company that the respondents selected at the outset of the survey, we identified eight different categories: automotive, banking, food, textile, etc. This control variable does not show a significant effect either ($p > 0.05$ in all paths).

In the second alternative model (Figure 3), all stimuli were combined into a single second-order construct (sustainability stimuli). However, in this model, the fit indices decreased substantially, suggesting that distinguishing sustainability stimuli as external and internal, as

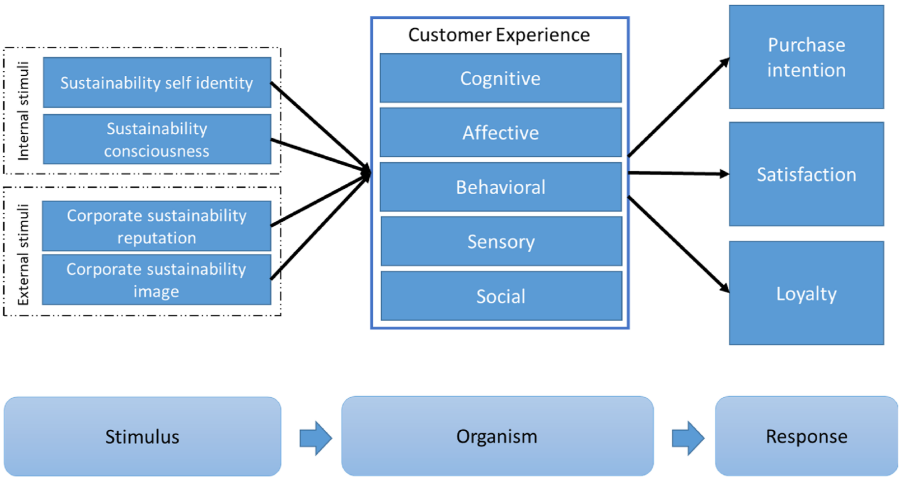


Figure 2. Alternative Model-I. Source: Authors' own work

Table 5. Structural equation model results of the alternative model

Path	β	*t*	Support
Sustainability Self-Identity → Customer Experience	0.14***	3.63	Yes
Sustainability Consciousness → Customer Experience	0.21***	5.09	Yes
Corporate Sustainability Image → Customer Experience	0.30***	8.09	Yes
Sustainability reputation → Customer Experience	0.22***	6.06	Yes
Customer Experience → Purchase Intention	0.89***	9.80	Yes
Customer Experience → Satisfaction	0.86***	10.07	Yes
Customer Experience → Loyalty	0.79***	9.37	Yes

Note(s): CFI = 0.90 IFI = 0.90 TLI = 0.90 RMSEA = 0.05
***$p < 0.001$
Source(s): Authors' own work

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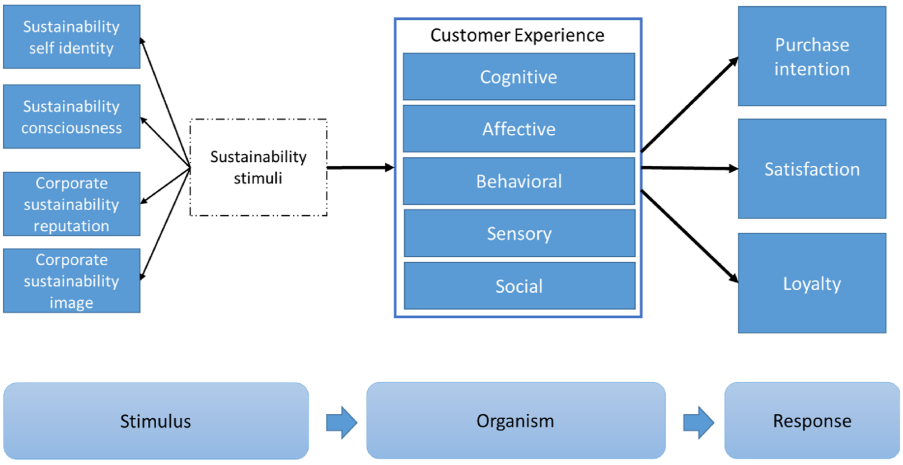


Figure 3. Alternative Model-II. Source: Authors' own work

opposed to treating them alike regardless of the source of the stimuli, is a better way to capture the impacts of sustainability-related triggers on customers' behavioral outcomes. In Table 6, the comparison of measurement models is presented.

Discussion

Traditionally, sustainability and customer experience have been treated as distinct variables, leaving a gap in understanding their interrelation (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Ünal *et al.*, 2024). This study addresses this gap by employing the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) framework (Jacoby, 2002), which provides a structured approach to examining how sustainability efforts influence customer experiences. The SOR model conceptualizes intrinsic and extrinsic triggers (stimuli), internal cognitive and emotional processes (organism), and behavioral outcomes (response), offering a lens for analyzing consumer behaviors (Wang *et al.*, 2024) and employee responses to organizational stimuli (De Clercq and Pereira, 2023; Teodorovicz *et al.*, 2024). Recent research highlights consumers' growing responsiveness to sustainability initiatives, recognizing their importance to corporate strategies (Jiang *et al.*, 2023; Fatima and Elbanna, 2023; Qu and Mardani, 2023).

Table 6. Comparison of measurement models

	Description	χ^2	df	$\Delta\chi^2$	CFI	TLI	IFI	RMSEA
Baseline Model	Two second order constructs Internal and external sustainability stimuli	2834.03	1731.00	–	0.93	0.93	0.93	0.04
Alternative Model-I	First order constructs	3373.59	1734.00	539.56	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.05
Alternative Model-II	One second order construct Sustainability stimuli	3806.57	1699.00	972.54	0.87	0.86	0.87	0.06

Source(s): Authors' own work

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As sustainability becomes central to customer decision-making, businesses face increasing pressure to integrate sustainability and customer experience into cohesive strategies (Becker and Jaakkola, 2020; Elmassri *et al.*, 2023). Customers often view organizations lacking sustainable practices as unfavorable (Unal and Tascioglu, 2022; Waqas *et al.*, 2023). However, challenges remain in operationalizing this integration effectively, prompting further investigation (Calza *et al.*, 2023). By addressing these practical barriers, our study contributes to management research by advancing knowledge on aligning environmental and customer considerations within business operations.

The results of our study point to the existence of two main groups of stimuli that contribute to creating and managing a sustainable customer experience. These stimuli shape both the customer journey and its subsequent results. In particular, our findings underscored the significance of internal stimuli, particularly the notions of sustainability, self-identity, and consciousness. These individual-level factors were revealed to exert a notably positive and substantial influence on customer experiences. This result supports our hypotheses (H1) and further reinforces the understanding that an individual's sense of identity and awareness can play a crucial role in shaping their perception of experiences.

Similarly, our investigation into external stimuli yielded noteworthy insights into the role of corporate sustainability image and reputation. We observed that these external factors also hold considerable sway over customer experiences, with a discernible positive and significant impact. Thus, our findings lent support to H2, indicating that the impressions evoked in consumers' minds due to external stimuli such as a favorable corporate sustainability image and clear sustainability reputation can significantly enhance the overall customer experience.

These results highlight the importance of alignment between the sustainability practices of companies and the sustainability engagement of customers: When customers are more informed about sustainability and identify themselves with the sustainability causes, they feel that they have a better experience with the products and services of sustainable companies. Therefore, our findings strongly suggest that activities to stimulate sustainability consciousness among the customer base should be placed among management practices. In addition, our findings show the significance of establishing a sustainable reputation and corporate image. Therefore, practices such as corporate social responsibility (CSR) or environmentally friendly projects that signal companies' commitment to sustainability goals are of paramount importance.

Moving from stimuli to the organism, our study revealed a critical linkage between customer experiences and subsequent customer responses. It is evident in the results that the customer experience plays a significant role in affecting key customer behaviors such as purchase intention, satisfaction, and loyalty. These outcomes were demonstrated to be positively and significantly associated with the nature of the customer experience encountered. Hence, our study offered robust support for H3, H4, and H5, reinforcing the idea that a positive, sustainable customer experience can foster enhanced customer responses.

Therefore, the findings of the study align with existing literature that highlights the positive relationship between strong sustainability triggers and customer experience. Research by Mustonen *et al.* (2016) demonstrates that a supplier's green image significantly enhances customer experience, particularly for environmentally conscious consumers. Similarly, Minkiewicz *et al.* (2011) emphasize the role of corporate images incorporating environmental considerations in shaping positive customer experiences. Mena *et al.* (2019) further assert that sustainability-centered approaches strengthen customer-brand relationships, suggesting that a strong sustainability image contributes to improved overall customer experience. At the same time, contrasting perspectives in the literature highlight the complexities involved in leveraging sustainability to enhance customer experiences. Jagani *et al.* (2024) argues that sustainability initiatives may fail to enhance customer experience if customers do not already have a positive relationship with the brand. Amos *et al.* (2019) note that consumer reactions to sustainability initiatives are not universally favorable, as individual values and expectations vary. Ioannou *et al.* (2023) add that perceived insincerity or exaggeration in sustainability

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claims can diminish customer experience, highlighting the critical role of authenticity in sustainability communications. Ünal *et al.* (2024) found that CX, while positively moderating the relationship between perceived sustainability benefits and loyalty, does not have a significant effect on the skepticism-loyalty relationship. Yang *et al.* (2019) noted that CX has a negative moderating role on the relationship between reputation and purchase intention but in that study CX is considered only as a form of purchase frequency as opposed to the broad customer experience indicator employed in our study, comprising affective, cognitive, social, behavioral, and sensory aspects. These findings collectively reinforce the significance of our results by highlighting the potential of sustainability practices to elevate customer experience. However, they also emphasize the need for organizations to approach sustainability initiatives strategically. These insights advance the understanding of how sustainability can be leveraged as a driver of enhanced customer experiences.

Theoretical contributions

The present study provides several valuable theoretical contributions to management, sustainability, and customer experience literature. Building on the SOR model at the junction between these two areas, we contribute to the understanding of how sustainability shapes customer experiences and behaviors. The SOR model allows us to uncover the underlying mechanisms through which sustainability practices influence customers' perceptions and attitudes. We may be able to better predict consumer responses and behavioral consequences by looking at stimuli, and in this case, the stimuli would include internal sustainability stimuli, i.e. sustainability self-identity or consciousness, and external stimuli, i.e. corporate sustainability image and reputation, and the organism, being the customer experience (Gao *et al.*, 2022; Suparno, 2020).

In this respect, the SOR framework was developed to explain the connection between internal and external stimuli, inner psychological perspectives, and resultant behavioral outcomes. Our study explores a new and significant area via this framework: the connection between sustainability and customer experience. Customer experience here is influenced by intrinsic and extrinsic factors like "self-identity" or "sustainability consciousness," along with "corporate sustainability reputation and image", which collectively affect consumer behavior. Therefore, the SOR framework is crucial for understanding how different stimuli affect people's inner experiences and behaviors across various contexts. One major implication of the SOR framework for decision-making is that it provides a systematic way to understand and manage customer experiences. Businesses should analyze cognitive factors in the environment, individual internal states, and their responses to develop strategies that improve consumer behavior. Additionally, the SOR framework helps us comprehend how internal and external stimuli impact consumer behavior, affecting satisfaction, loyalty, and purchase intentions. Thus, the SOR framework is invaluable for understanding customer experiences and how these experiences shape consumer decision-making processes.

Our study responds to the call for more research on the synergy between customer-centricity and sustainability (Calza *et al.*, 2023; Khan and Fatma, 2023; Signori *et al.*, 2019). Accordingly, we apply the SOR model to demonstrate how these two concepts connect and influence each other in business contexts. One key contribution of our work is identifying and classifying the sources driving sustainable customer experiences (Verma *et al.*, 2021). We highlight the roles of both internal and external factors and how they uniquely shape the customer journey. This deeper insight expands the theoretical framework regarding what influences sustainable customer experiences.

Specifically, our exploration of sustainability self-identity and consciousness as internal stimuli has enriched the literature by emphasizing the impact of individual-level factors on the perception of sustainable customer experiences. Our findings align with previous literature (Balderjahn and Hüttel, 2019), marking a significant step in understanding how a company's public image and communication strategies shape customer perceptions.

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For businesses aiming to effectively address their sustainable initiatives, it is crucial to recognize how their company's sustainability image and reputation impact customer behavior (O'Connor and Assaker, 2022; Yingfei *et al.*, 2022). As such, businesses can gain insights into the factors that drive customer loyalty and purchasing decisions by examining how customers perceive and respond to a company's sustainability practices. This indicates that businesses can be guided by this knowledge, creating a positive sustainability image that resonates with the target market, leading to improved customer experiences and enhanced support for the organization's sustainability efforts (Rather, 2020; Yingfei *et al.*, 2022). Moreover, our theoretical contribution further validates the direct link between sustainable customer experiences and subsequent customer responses. By doing this, we seek to add to the theoretical foundation that the positive relationship between such constructs as purchase intention, satisfaction, and loyalty together with customers' experiences needs to be strengthened for the long-term success of the business.

Managerial implications

Our research highlights actionable strategies for managers aiming to integrate sustainability into business practices and enhance customer experiences. Extending sustainability consciousness among customers is paramount and can be achieved through transparent communication of eco-friendly initiatives such as responsible sourcing, waste reduction, and sustainable product designs. Tesla exemplifies this approach by sharing detailed impact reports, designing electric vehicles with environmentally responsible materials, reducing manufacturing waste, and promoting battery recycling programs. This transparency not only builds a loyal customer base but also reinforces the company's sustainability-driven brand reputation. Similarly, IKEA's sustainability efforts combine climate-positive goals with customer engagement by offering eco-friendly products, sustainable packaging, and recycling initiatives that demonstrate tangible benefits like cost savings and enhanced loyalty.

Maintaining a positive corporate sustainability image is crucial, as consumers prefer companies perceived as committed to sustainability. Effective communication must be transparent, authentic, and credible, emphasizing competitive advantages like cost reduction, stronger brand reputation, and greater loyalty. Framing sustainability as a business necessity rather than an optional strategy is essential to gaining stakeholder and investor buy-in. Companies should also embed sustainability into every stage of the customer journey, from designing environmentally friendly retail spaces and packaging to offering sustainable options throughout their operations. For instance, Hilton's "Travel with Purpose" program empowers employees as sustainability ambassadors who engage guests and provide clear guidance on eco-friendly practices, enhancing customer satisfaction and loyalty. Similarly, retailers can leverage sustainability self-identity to increase loyalty and create a favorable experience by adopting eco-friendly practices and transparent communication, as demonstrated by Patagonia. Patagonia has committed to eliminating virgin petroleum materials from its products by 2025, replacing them with preferred materials such as recycled polyester. This shift not only reduces reliance on fossil fuels but also cuts CO_2e emissions by 50%, based on the Higg Materials Sustainability Index. Patagonia's transparency about its climate goals, such as its commitment to net-zero emissions by 2040, has strengthened customer trust and loyalty, providing a model for other retailers to follow. The brand's commitment to making 100% of its packaging reusable, home-compostable, renewable, or easily recyclable by 2025 provides a roadmap for companies in logistics and packaging-intensive industries. The company is already using algae ink, removing plastic, and implementing QR code technology to reduce paper usage by 100,000 pounds annually. This proactive approach to sustainability highlights the importance of setting measurable goals and holding oneself accountable, a practice that can inspire similar efforts across industries. Patagonia's emphasis on customer-focused sustainability serves as a powerful example of how companies can integrate sustainability into their core operations while enhancing customer experiences. For example, as a

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consequence of this strong commitment to sustainability, Patagonia have enjoyed a considerably higher assessment score (166 points out of 200) compared to the benchmarked companies operating in the same industry (99 points out of 200) according to the 2024 Annual B Corp (Benefit Corporation) report, where companies are evaluated across five impact areas: Environment, Communities, Customers, Workers, and Governance. Similarly, several industry reports suggest that Patagonia's efforts to place sustainability at the center of their corporate strategy have yielded beneficial outcomes for the company in terms of loyalty, customer engagement and purchase intentions.

In light of such positive outcomes on the customer-company relationship thanks to sustainability-related practices, managers should also prioritize data-driven approaches to monitor and improve sustainability initiatives' impact on customer perceptions. Feedback mechanisms, analytics, and surveys can measure effectiveness, ensuring efforts meet their objectives. Hilton's use of guest feedback and analytics to refine its sustainability practices highlights the importance of adaptability. Empowering frontline employees with tools and knowledge further supports sustainability integration, creating meaningful customer interactions aligned with environmental goals. These steps position organizations to improve both business outcomes and societal contributions effectively.

This study highlights the positive relationship between sustainability and customer experience, but it is important to acknowledge the practical challenges organizations may face when attempting to operationalize these constructs. Specifically, integrating sustainability reputation and image into customer experience strategies can be hindered by financial constraints. The costs associated with communicating sustainability practices, enhancing the corporate sustainability perception, and implementing eco-friendly initiatives may be substantial. In addition, resistance from both internal and external stakeholders—such as employees or investors—who may prioritize short-term profitability over long-term sustainability goals could undermine efforts to align these constructs. Overcoming these barriers requires organizations to effectively integrate sustainability into their corporate image and communication strategies, ensuring that stakeholders understand the long-term benefits of sustainability-driven customer experiences. By addressing these challenges, businesses can strengthen the connection between sustainability initiatives and customer experience, ultimately fostering positive customer behaviors such as loyalty and purchase intention.

Limitations and future research directions

Although our current study provided valuable insights into the interplay between sustainability, consumer experience, and consumer behavior, it is important to acknowledge a few limitations and suggest avenues for further research. Future research should explore cultural differences in the relationship between sustainability, consumer experience, and behavior to enhance contextual understanding. Examining how diverse cultural perceptions influence responses to sustainability policies could yield valuable insights.

While the sample provides a solid foundation for preliminary insights, it may constrain the generalizability of the findings to broader consumer populations. The use of a student-assisted distribution method, though effective for efficient data collection, may not adequately capture the full spectrum of consumer behaviors across diverse demographics. Future research should address these limitations by expanding the sample to include a more varied group of respondents from different cultural and socioeconomic backgrounds, thereby enhancing external validity. Additionally, the reliance on self-reported measures introduces potential biases, such as social desirability and respondent subjectivity. To minimize these, the survey was designed with neutral phrasing and employed a five-point Likert scale to reduce response bias. Nevertheless, future studies could strengthen validation by integrating objective behavioral measures or employing alternative methods, such as experimental or qualitative designs, to provide a more comprehensive understanding of consumer behavior. Moreover, this study does not explicitly investigate cultural or contextual differences that could influence

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the applicability of its findings across diverse markets. Exploring how sustainability-oriented stimuli impact consumer behavior in different cultural settings would not only broaden the study's scope but also enhance the generalizability of its results across varied geographic and cultural contexts.

Additionally, to gain a more comprehensive view of the impact of sustainability projects, we propose adopting a longitudinal study. Future research can reveal the results and strategies of sustainability by examining the evolution of the impact of sustainability on customer experience over time. This long-term projection will enable companies to make informed decisions that consider the ongoing impact of their sustainability efforts. Furthermore, emerging technologies' changing role in enhancing sustainable customer experience deserves closer scrutiny. Research exploring how technologies such as artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and blockchain can be used to develop participatory and transparent sustainability initiatives aligns well with the ever-evolving technological landscape. Understanding these dynamics can open up new opportunities for companies to engage consumers in the sustainability journey. Last but not least, it is imperative to recognize the sector-specific nuances that influence the relationship between sustainability and customer experiences. Whether it is fashion, food, cars, or technology, all of these industries have their own unique obstacles and advantages in how they can best incorporate sustainable practices. The sectoral studies will shed light on these unique characteristics, and it will allow firms in these sectors to have some sector-specific knowledge.

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About the authors

Umut Unal is a PhD student in the Department of Management at Istanbul Medeniyet University. His research focuses on sustainability, consumer psychology, consumer behavior and corporate branding.

Rıfgı Buğra Bağcı (PhD) is an Assistant Professor at Istanbul Sabahattin Zaim University, Business Administration. He is also currently a Visiting Researcher at the Department of Operations Management, Copenhagen Business School, funded by TUBITAK doctoral research scholarship program. His current research interests include service operations and marketing, servitization, sustainability, and supply chain management. Rıfgı Buğra Bağcı is the corresponding author and can be contacted at: bugra.bagci@izu.edu.tr

Mertcan Taşçıoğlu (Ph.D., Georgia Southern University) is an Associate Professor of Marketing at Istanbul Medeniyet University. His research includes ethical and social issues in consumer decision-making, international/ cross-cultural consumer behavior, sustainability, and green marketing.

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